Overseas students bring Math Made Simple project to Makhanda youth

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A group of students from Houston, Texas, are set to visit Makhanda to share their educational initiative, Math Made Simple, to empower children at local schools, churches and community organisations.

The project, founded by Keshav Harpavat, began as a small tutoring effort in Houston and has grown into a programme connecting youth across the globe through problem-solving and collaboration.

The group will arrive in Frontier Country on Wednesday and work in the community until Saturday.

They will also work on a short documentary exploring SA's anti-apartheid history, interviewing professors, church leaders, and locals to highlight diverse perspectives on resistance movements.

Harpavat said he initially started Math Made Simple because he was interested in sharing his love for problem-solving, logic, and mathematics with his community.

> **'After I realised the vast potential that mathematics could have on building relationships and connecting with others, I came to the wonderful understanding that this programme could be something much greater than simply a math instruction programme'**

"This started as a localised Houston effort, working with children through basic tutoring on their after-school homework. After I realised the vast potential that mathematics could have on building relationships and connecting with others, I came to the wonderful understanding that this programme could be something much greater than simply a math instruction programme," Harpavat said.

The Houston students have partnered with Awarenet, an organisation in Makhanda that focuses on improving technology and education literacy among youth.

Through this partnership, the team has been conducting virtual tutoring sessions with local children in preparation for the SA Mathematics Olympiad.

Harpavat said more than 100 pupils from various schools were taking part in the programme.

"Impact wise, we have seen the children improve on their basic mathematical skills, including addition, subtraction, multiplication, division, fractions, word problems, and so on.

"Just by daily interaction, we have had the ability to learn more about the culture of South Africa from our students; as we go on our trip, I am more than confident that this connection will be amplified," he said.

During their visit, the team will visit local schools including Fikizolo Primary and St Andrew's, as well as engage with community organisations such as the Black Power Station and Amazwi Museum.

"This experience allows us to visit a different part of the world that is rich with history, culture, and diversity.

"As aspiring leaders, this will shape our ability to think critically about the past and use this information to shape future decisions that could impact the world.

"More importantly, it will allow us to connect deeply with youth just like us, on the other side of the world, listening to their stories and cultural experiences as well as sharing ours."

Keshav Harpavat — leading a learning session — and his team are set to visit Makhanda to share his Math Made Simple initiative with local youth

Bay's 'Joliza' to headline Zabalaza Fest in Cape Town

Simtembile Mgidi

The hard work and artistic prowess of award-winning Gqeberha musician Thandikhaya "Joliza" Magayiyana will see him reach a new milestone in his career as one of the headline acts at the 16th annual Baxter Zabalaza Theatre Festival in Cape Town.

Shortly after his Cape Town performance on March 18, he will return to his Ushuni WeBhaca Tour in Johannesburg at the Kings Kraal on April 3.

The latter will see the 35-year-old singer-songwriter share the stage with acts such as a capella group The Soil, Zawadi, Nathi Mankayi, Sifiso "Damase Ivulandlela" Nene and Phila Madlingozi.

Magayiyana, from Walmer Location, said he felt blessed to be performing alongside artists he admired.

"I never thought I would work with such artists that I grew up listening to.

"I had dreamt of working with them one day.

"People have welcomed my music, when I check on the statistics on digital platforms such as Spotify. Johannesburg as well as Cape Town on a weekly basis alternate at the number one spot of consumers for my music, which are at least over 50,000," Magayiyana said.

The Baxter will come alive as a vibrant festival hub from March 13-22, with a programme featuring drama, comedy, theatre, live music, workshops, panel discussions, an exhibition and, of course, delicious food and drinks on offer.

The festival is a celebration of identity, community, creativity and resilience — displayed through inspiring theatre and dynamic storytelling.

Magayiyana said due to demand for his music in Johannesburg as well as Cape Town, he had decided to bring his pre-launch album tour to both cities.

It was during the Cape Town leg of his tour in September last year that he made a lasting impression on one of the festival organisers who was in the crowd.

"One of the organisers came to watch my pre-launch in Cape Town. He loved my performance then asked for my contact details because they wanted me to be part of their festival," Magayiyana said.

"What makes me really happy is that I am one of the headline acts in the festival.

"It makes me want to give a show-stopping performance to show why I deserve to be a headline act."

Magayiyana joined Gallo Record Company and Gallo Music Publishers in late 2024, and his musical journey has been one of discipline, tears, hard work and dedication.

Thandikhaya 'Joliza' Magayiyana, from Walmer, is set to perform as one of the headline acts at the 16th annual Baxter Zabalaza Theatre Festival in Cape Town next month

"It took some time for me to accept that I was now a headline act from being an opening act.

"What I love is that I did not miss a single step in my musical journey.

"I had fallen, risen, cried, got back up, dusted myself off and continued moving forward, believing that one day what I was doing would make the livelihood of my family better.

"When I first performed, I moved from getting paid with a 2*l* bottle of fizzy drink, then a small amount of money, to where I am now, hence I say I never had any short cuts," he said.

Festival artistic director and curator Mdu Kweyama said this year, the organisers were presenting an exciting combined programme of curated work from artist proposals and productions.

"In doing so, we are thrilled to be returning to our roots, finding stories and theatre-makers in the heart of our communities.

"And bringing them alive on stage as full productions through mentorship and skills development."

African Food Festival adds to New Brighton's township tourist attractions

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The Friendly City, long known for its traditional dishes, is also becoming a haven for cosmopolitan palates.

In New Brighton on Saturday, Café Riza hosted an African Food Festival, using the finest local cuisine to help boost township tourism.

Kwaito legend and reality TV star Zwai Bala attended the festival.

The festival, showcasing some of the finest African cuisine, formed part of the café's official launch.

From hearty starch-based dishes and vibrant vegetable bowls to fresh salads and protein-packed meals, the festival offered something for every palate.

The menu was rounded off with mocktails, homemade ginger beer and even pizza slices.

It was held opposite the New Brighton police station.

Café owner and festival organiser Vuyokazi Duze said she had intended to host her annual African Food Festival in Richmond Hill in 2025.

However, due to unforeseen circumstances, she could not.

She thought there was no better way to introduce the festival than at the launch of her own café.

"The festival was meant to celebrate our own cultural food in a modern way, but I also wanted to show people what I was capable of doing.

"I will host the African Food Festival again in September, at my own venue.

"At this festival, I had different vendors.

New Brighton's Café Riza owner Vuyokazi Duze with guest speaker Mike Pantsi at the launch of the African Food Festival Picture: THULANI LUPONDWANA

"However, they are limited to the market that they are exposed to.

"I intended to expose these different people to a larger market that would come to the festival.

"I also wanted children from the location to have a sense of pride in their culture, because other countries have a sense of pride in who they are, like Italians are proud of eating pizza," Duze said.

Mike Pantsi, a former Nelson Mandela Bay Tourism chair, was the guest speaker at the festival.

Pantsi said hospitality was the perfect tourism pairing.

"Tourism is everybody's business, and everyone has to play their part," Pantsi, who is also a tour guide, said.

The festival featured a spread of traditional favourites, including livers, chicken trotters and free-range chicken known as *umleqwa*, alongside other dishes commonly prepared in the township.

With few festivals and events hosted in New Brighton, Pantsi said the initiative formed part of broader efforts to revive tourism in the area.

"We will bring all tourism product owners together so that we complement each other here in New Brighton, so that we can put together a brochure.

"That will allow people to know when they come to New Brighton what they can expect to do.

"There is also a structure that will represent the community tourism forum.

"We do not want people to talk about Soweto only when we have the rich history of New Brighton.

"For instance, when the late Bishop Bolana [of the Bantu Church of Christ] passed on, we saw the big value of what churches could contribute to tourism as well," Pantsi said.

Explaining the history behind New Brighton's famous relish, he said the meal was prepared as a symbol of warmth, care and hospitality.

"A lot of people have heard the stories of our relish [called bisto in New Brighton], but not a lot of people have tasted an actual New Brighton relish.

"How our relish got famous was due to Gqeberha being known as the Friendly City.

"Now there is nothing as nice as something with a bit of oil in it, even when a person has a babalaza [hangover].

"Most of the time, onions would be mixed with tomato, a bit of curry, if your bread is ready, you'd marry it together, enjoy," Pantsi said.

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